

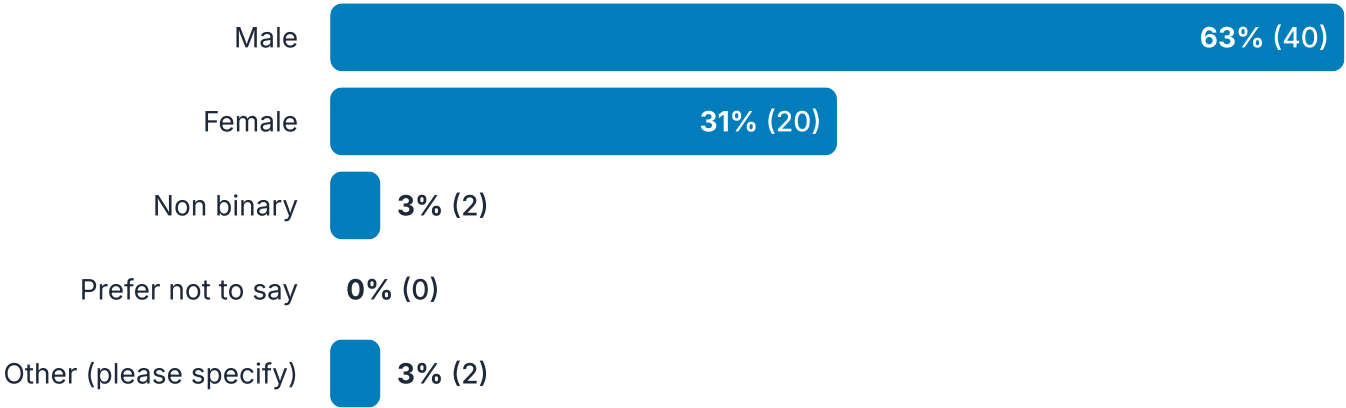
How Young People Manage Stress and Everyday Challenges

Welcome! Ready to help design something genuinely useful? 🚀

Most wellbeing apps expect you to journal, meditate, or pour out your feelings. But what if that's just not your style? I want to know how you really handle everyday pressure and stress. As part of my MSc in User Experience and Service Design at Loughborough University, I am researching how young people stay motivated so we can build a new kind of digital tool for young men. We aren't looking at passive solutions; we want to design something practical, action-orientated, and useful. While we are designing this with young men in mind, we want to hear perspectives from people of all genders. There are no right or wrong answers, and your input will directly shape what gets built! The Details: ⌚ Time: Just 7-10 minutes of your time. 🔒 Privacy: Completely anonymous and confidential. Before we begin, by clicking 'Next', you confirm that: 1. You are aged 18 years or older. 2. You have read the study information. 3. You voluntarily agree to participate.

Section A – About You

1. Which of the following best describes your gender? Responses: 64



Other (please specify)

- nonbinary man – some questions required me to misidentify myself with uppercase "I" pronouns. It is important to me that you are aware that these answers do NOT reflect my identity. my first-person pronouns are ALWAYS lowercase.
- transgirl

2. What is your age? Responses: 64

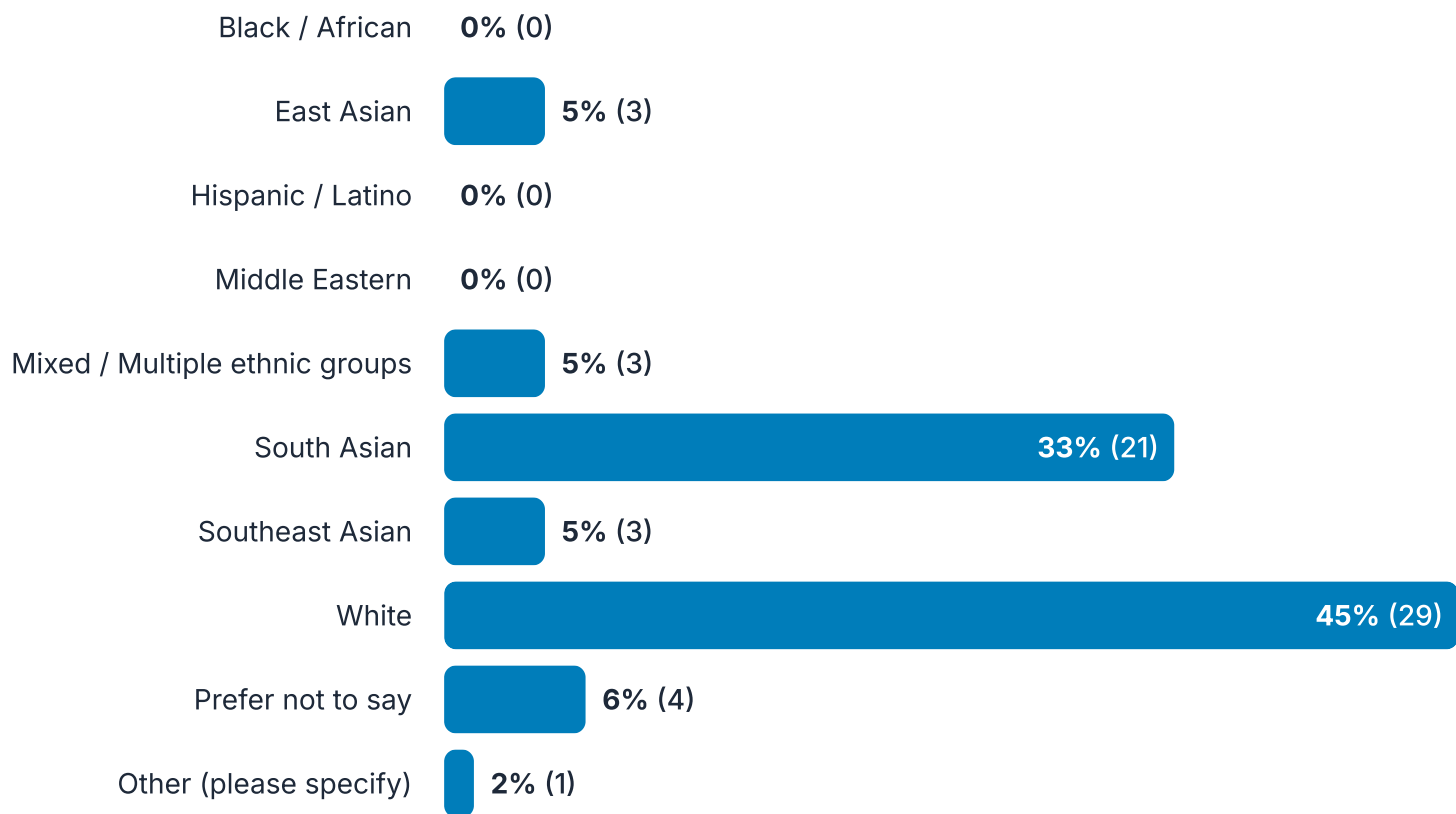


31-35 0% (0)

36 or above 16% (10)

3. What is your ethnic background?

Responses: 64



Other (please specify)

White - Irish

4. Which country do you currently reside in?

Responses: 64



Other (please specify)

Canada

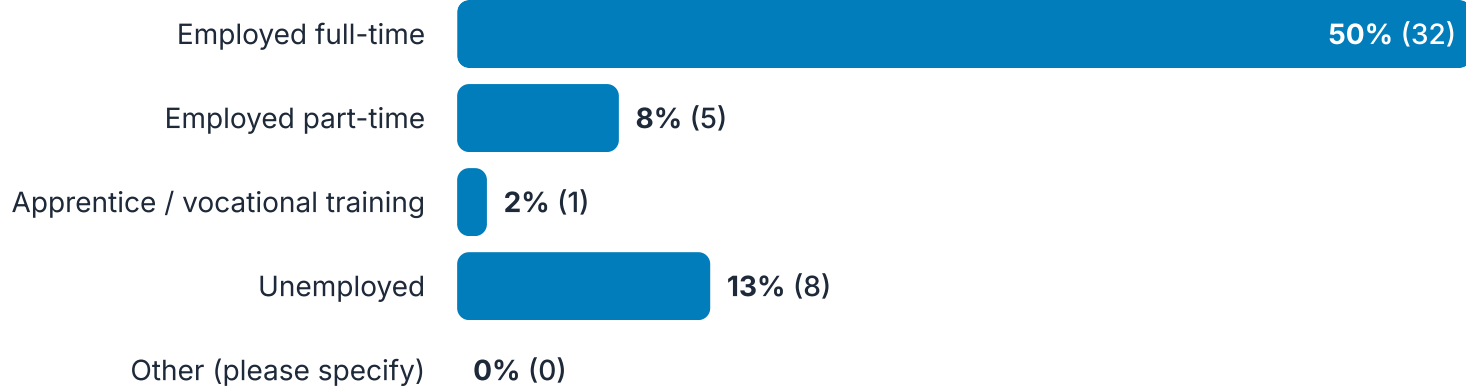
- United States
- USA
- united states of america
- Canada
- Greece
- Germany
- USA
- Finland
- germany
- Poland
- Latvia
- Malaysia
- Canada
- Netherlands
- USA
- USA
- Germany
- United States of America

5. Which best describes your current situation?

Responses: 64

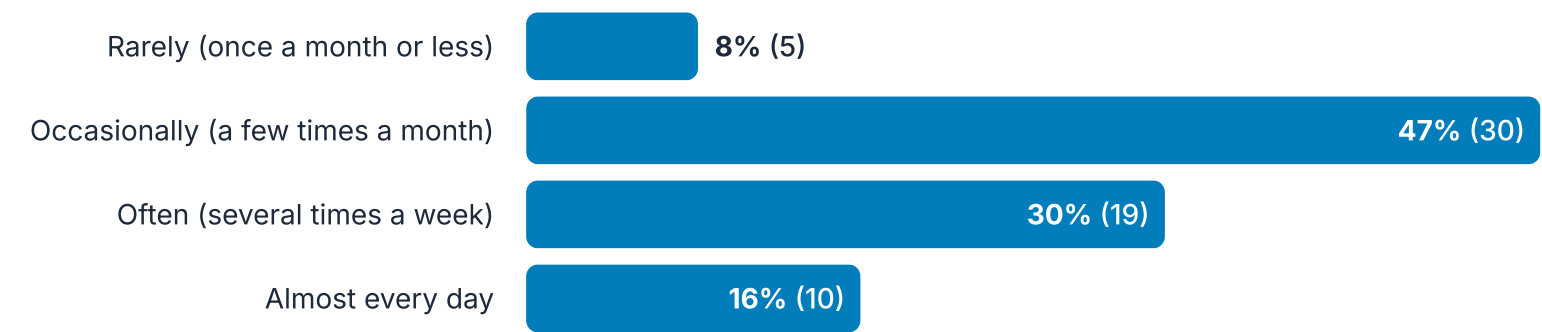
University student (full-time) 25% (16)

University student (part-time) 3% (2)

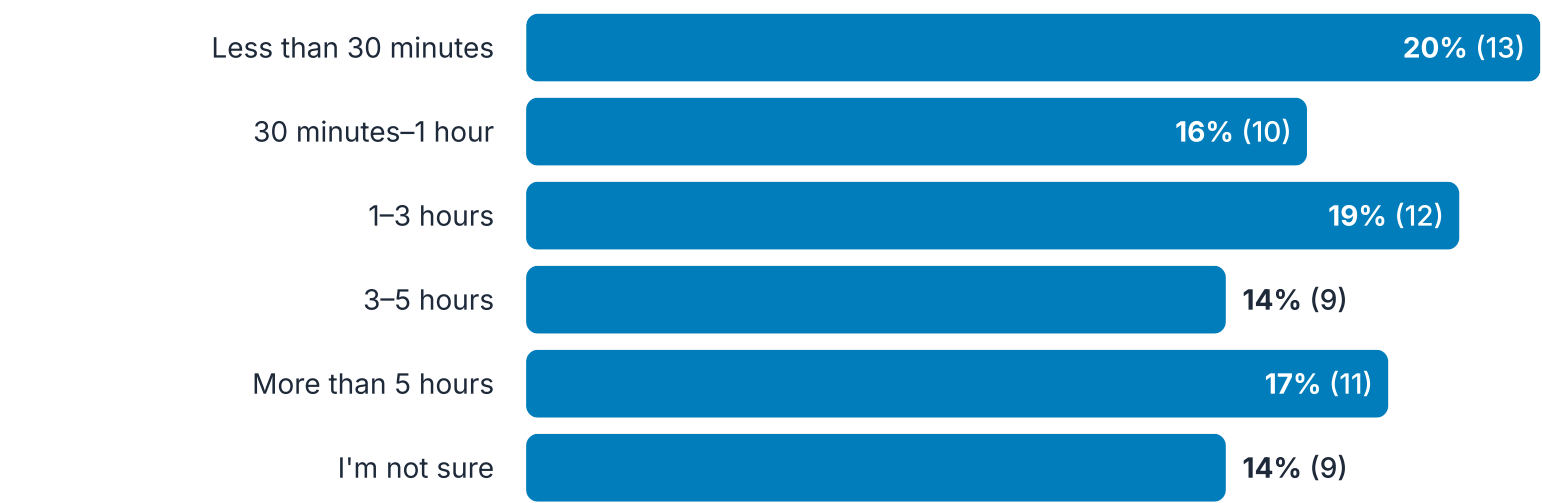


Section B – How You Deal with Stress

6. How often do you feel under noticeable pressure or stress? Responses: 64

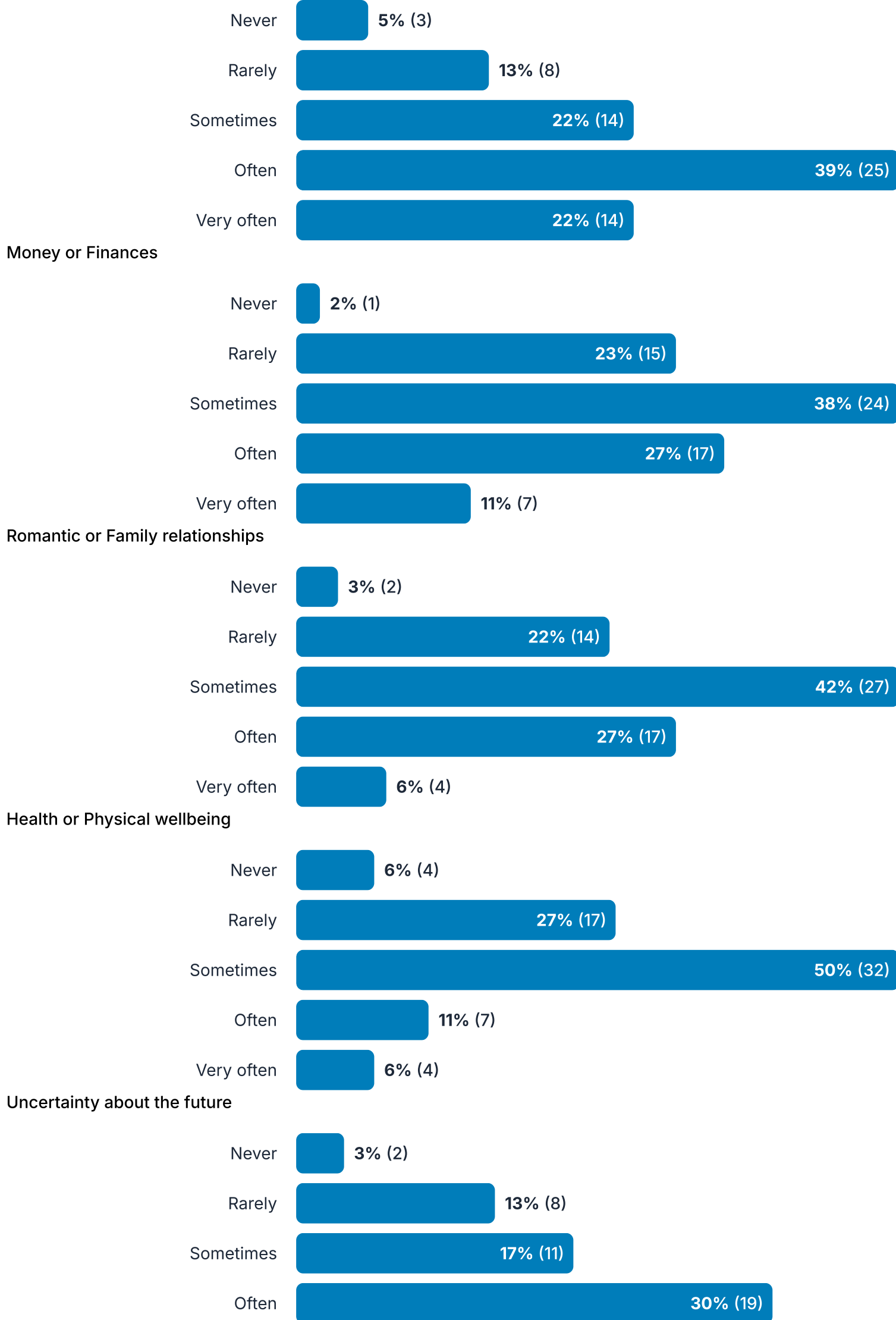


7. In a typical week, how much time do you intentionally spend on activities that support your mental wellbeing? Responses: 64



8. How often do the following contribute to your stress? Responses: 64

Work or University

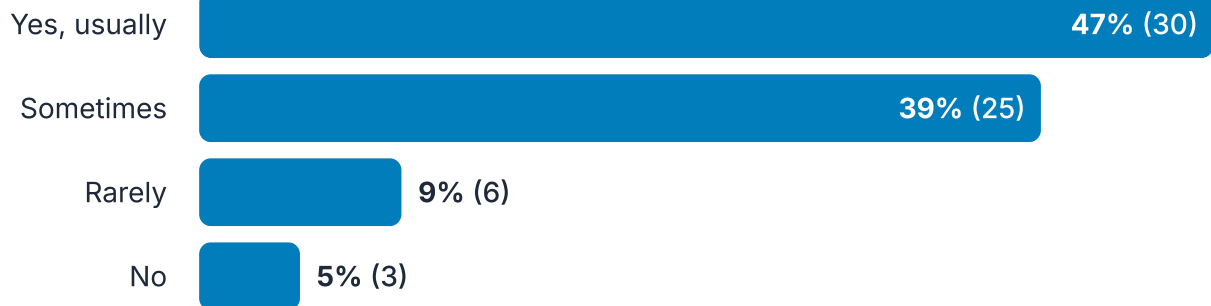


Very often

38% (24)

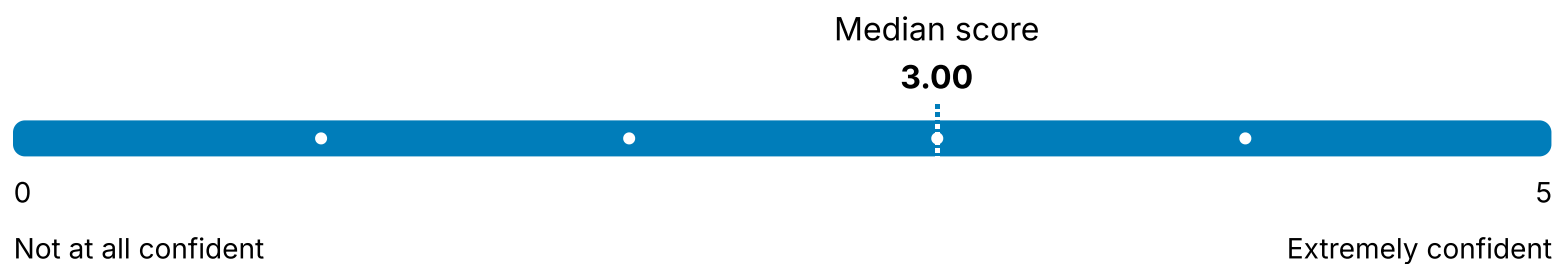
9. Are you usually aware when your stress is gradually building up?

Responses: 64



10. How confident are you in managing stress on your own?

Responses: 64

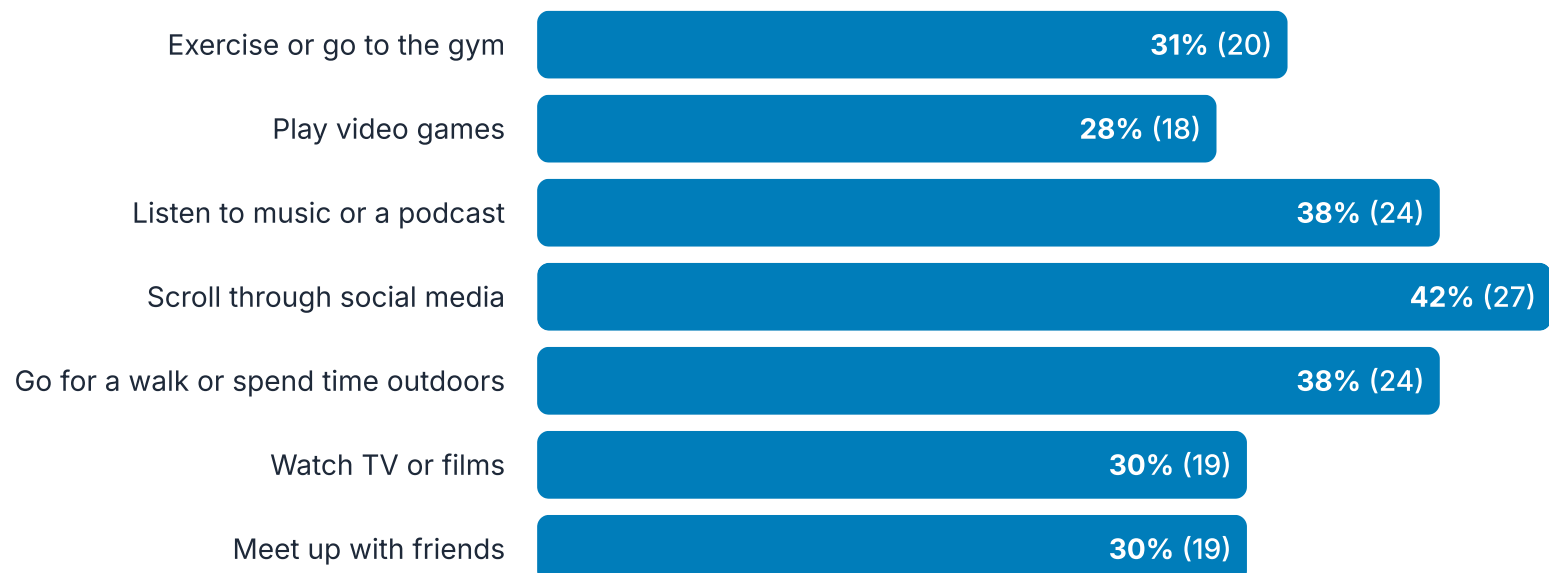


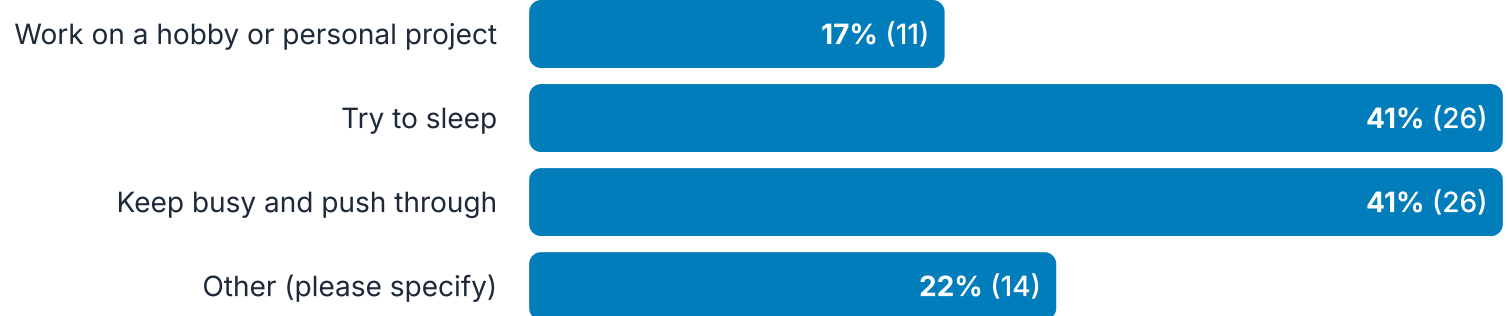
Statistics

Mean	Median	Minimum	Maximum	Range	Variance	Std. deviation
2.73	3.00	0.00	5.00	5.00	1.16	1.08

11. When you first notice you're stressed, what do you usually do? (Select all that apply)

Responses: 64





Other (please specify)

I usually find myself starting to organize or tidy up my room.

Cook or bake something

Yoga or reading

Go on a drive

Smoke or drink

In the short term, notice the noticing of it. Everything usually follows from there (breath, self-care, nurturing, or doing whatever is the cause behind it, which is sometimes as simple as "i'm tired" or "i'm hungry")

sleep a lot

Nothing

Go out with my partner

Think about what is causing stress and why. Rationalise my thinking and response if I can.

try to identify the source of the stress to see if I can change anything

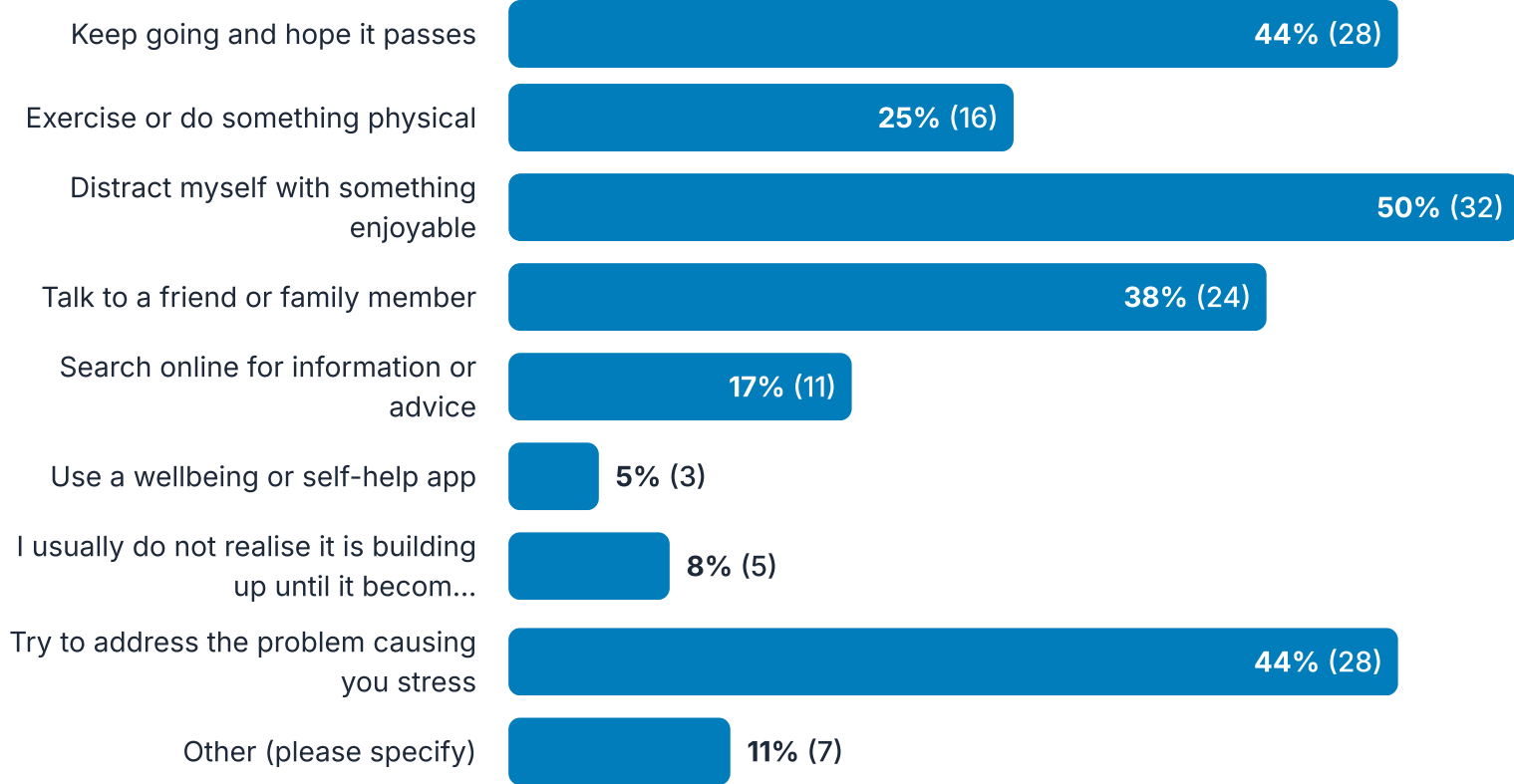
Ignore it

Mediatation or NSSI

Meditation

12. When stress continues for several days, what do you usually do? (Select all that apply)

Responses: 64



Other (please specify)

Recently, I'm thinking about getting a screenless device like WHOOP, Cirqa, or Fitbit and connecting it to Bevel, so I can track my stress levels with actual data. Then I can better understand when I'm under stress and find ways to deal with it.

If i can take the action to address it, i work on it or else i leave it on god and hope it passes

Nothing but exist, because this has been going on daily for my entire life and there is no escaping it

Work on not letting it turn into anger. Rest more. These situations are only ever work-related so I just ride them out and do as much as I can to reduce their impact.

talk to my therapist

Tell my partner I'm stressed

Speak to professional

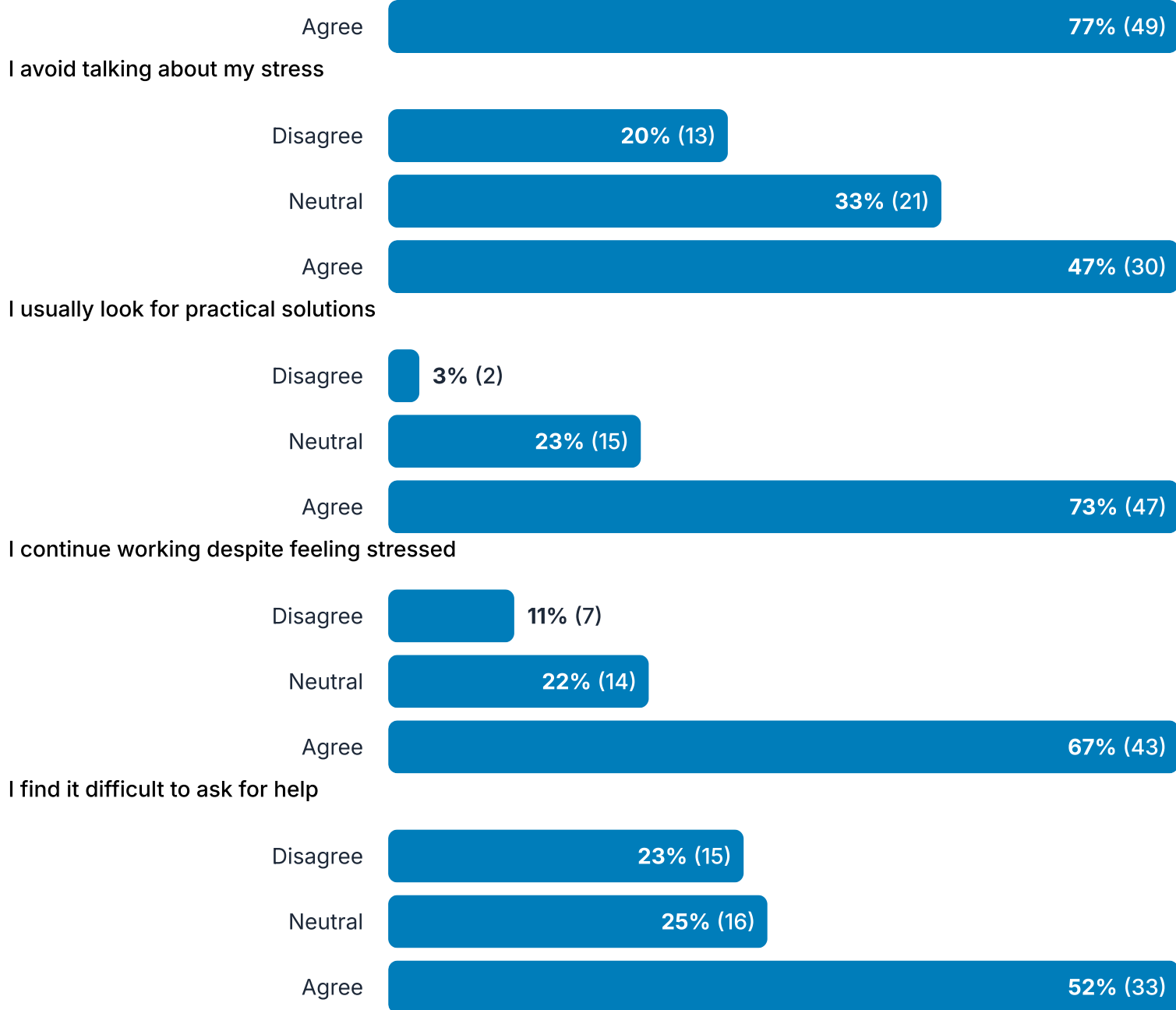
13. Please indicate how much you agree.

Responses: 64

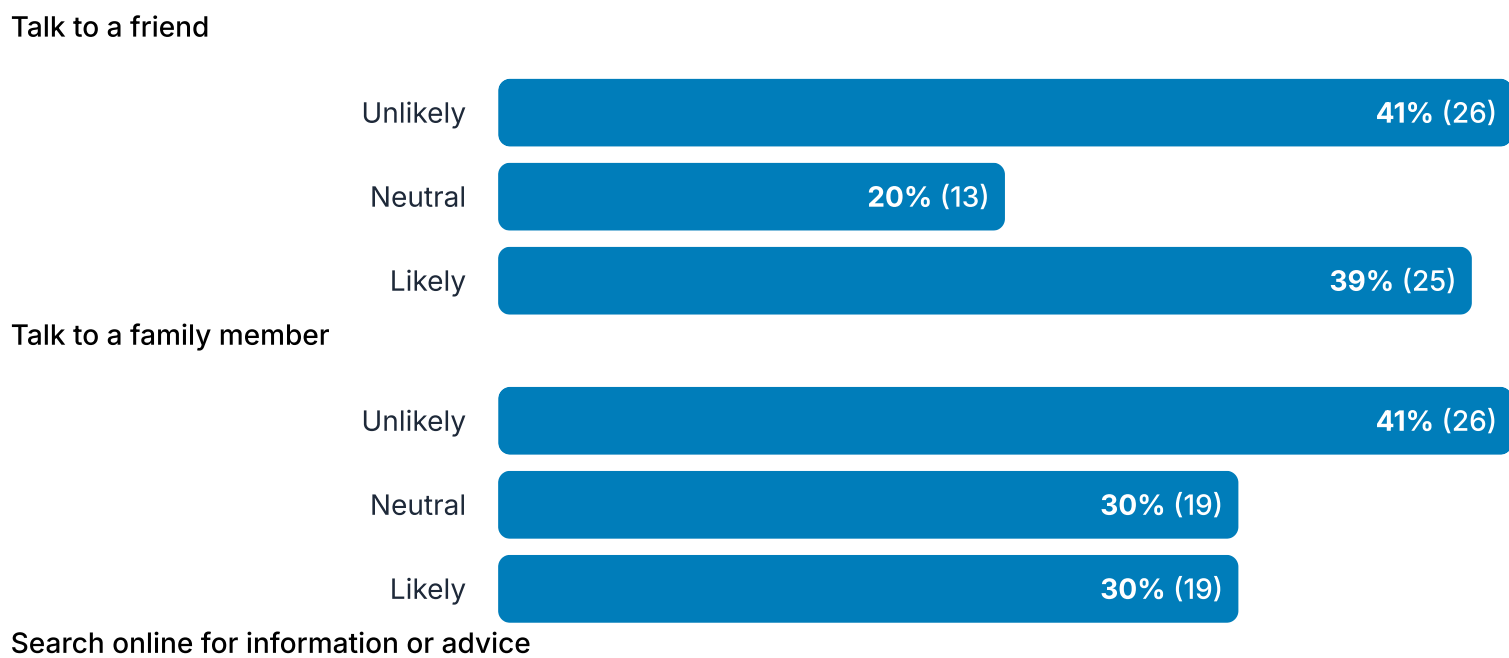
I prefer solving problems on my own

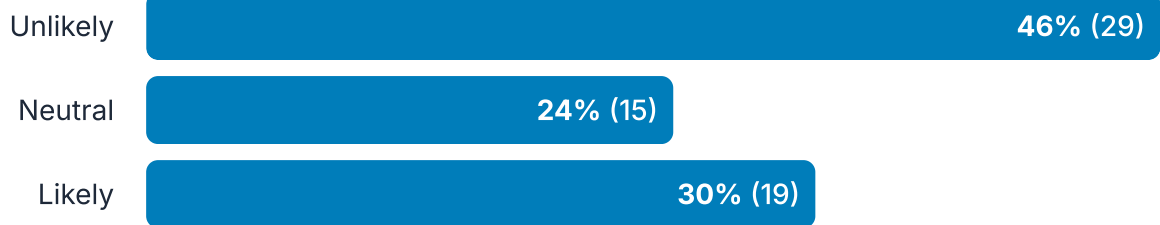
Disagree 6% (4)

Neutral 17% (11)

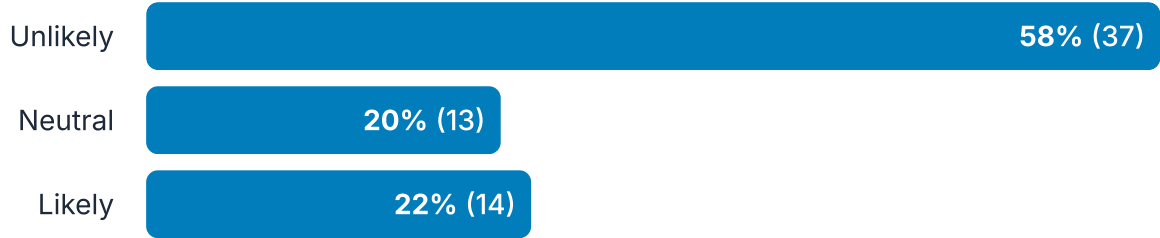


14. If you experienced significant stress tomorrow, how likely would you be to... Responses: 64





Use an AI chatbot (e.g., ChatGPT) for advice or support



Use a wellbeing or mental health app



Speak to a counsellor



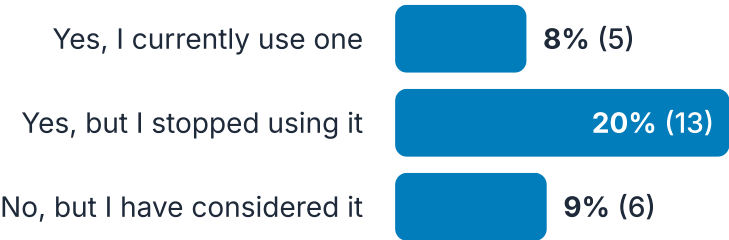
Do nothing and wait for it to pass



Section C – Digital Wellbeing Tools

15. Have you ever used a wellbeing or mental health app?

Responses: 64



16. Which wellbeing or mental health app(s) have you used or considered?

Responses: 24

How I feel

Headspace, Insight Timer, Sleep Cycle

Not any specific one, just in general have considered

calm

Headspace

miracle of mind and level suoermind

Finch, calm, waking up

Finch

Silvercloud.

Calm for a while. Now I just use Insight Timer (but mostly just for the timer). In case it's relevant, I also use Hevy for logging my gym/exercise, Apple Health/Fitness for tracking my sleep patterns, MacroFactor for organising my nutrition, and SparkHydrate for making sure I am drinking enough water - I consider all of these apps part of my mental health / wellbeing routine.

Headspace

Samsung Health and Fitnesspal

I cannot remember but I have used in the past.

two or three, I don't remember their names

Calm, headspace

It helped noting positive things but I just didn't find it useful .

Headspace and Calm also a couple of others I don't remember the name of.

Molehill mountain and I am sober

MindDoc

I forget

Daily Bean

headspace

Medito

N/A

17. What did you like or dislike about the app(s)

Responses: 18

It allowed me to put my emotions into words

Mostly, I start using these apps because I'm trying to solve a specific problem. But once the problem passes or I get used to it, I usually never open the app again.

not very personal.

Too many options, too little value

Likes: It's fun and is good as a reminder for certain things Dislikes: It demands engagement a bit much sometimes

Wasnt helpful. Most 'techniques' didn't make the stress go away, just acted as a temp distraction. I'm capable of distracting myself. The rest was stuff like meditation and soothing audio and whatnot. Nothing that helps actually prevent stress.

I never need to "share with a friend" - I dislike those which are based around social sharing. I do not need that kind of accountability to keep motivated and find it takes up room/attention in the apps. I also don't need vast libraries of guided meditations / community forums in Insight Timer - I originally got the app as a meditation timer years ago and it has grown and grown around what is still a very good meditation timer app! My number one priority is that the apps communicate well with something like Apple Health so that if I want I can view the data in different ways. I do not need AI help ever and avoid apps with this as their focus - a smart algorithm like MacroFactor is based on is much more effective than current AI tools, which are prone to error / assumption in a way that a good solid math-based data-driven algorithm isn't. I don't need the apps to "get to know me", I just need them to function as advertised.

Cost too much

I like the calorie and step count tracking options and also check ins of moods

The user interface seemed too busy and not subtle and minimal.

They're apps. I do not habitually use my phone on a daily basis so I forget they are there

It didn't add anything.

They all just felt like one more task to do while not really offering anything useful. They seem entirely generic and aimed at discussing or dealing with feelings rather than providing actual solutions. All talk and no substance.

It feels intrusive and reminds me of my problems when they are not troubling me. For example, with I am sober, I used it to quantify my sobriety progress (I love seeing numbers go up), but now, I'm 31 month sober already. The app only reminds me that I'm an addict and makes me suffer by making me remember alcohol and breeds more urges when without the app, alcohol doesn't even come to mind even when I'm stressed, maybe once every few months under extreme circumstances. Not using the app makes remaining sober easier.

I liked that it made me take a moment out of the day to reflect. I disliked how easy it was to ignore, and how it became a little formulaic at times.

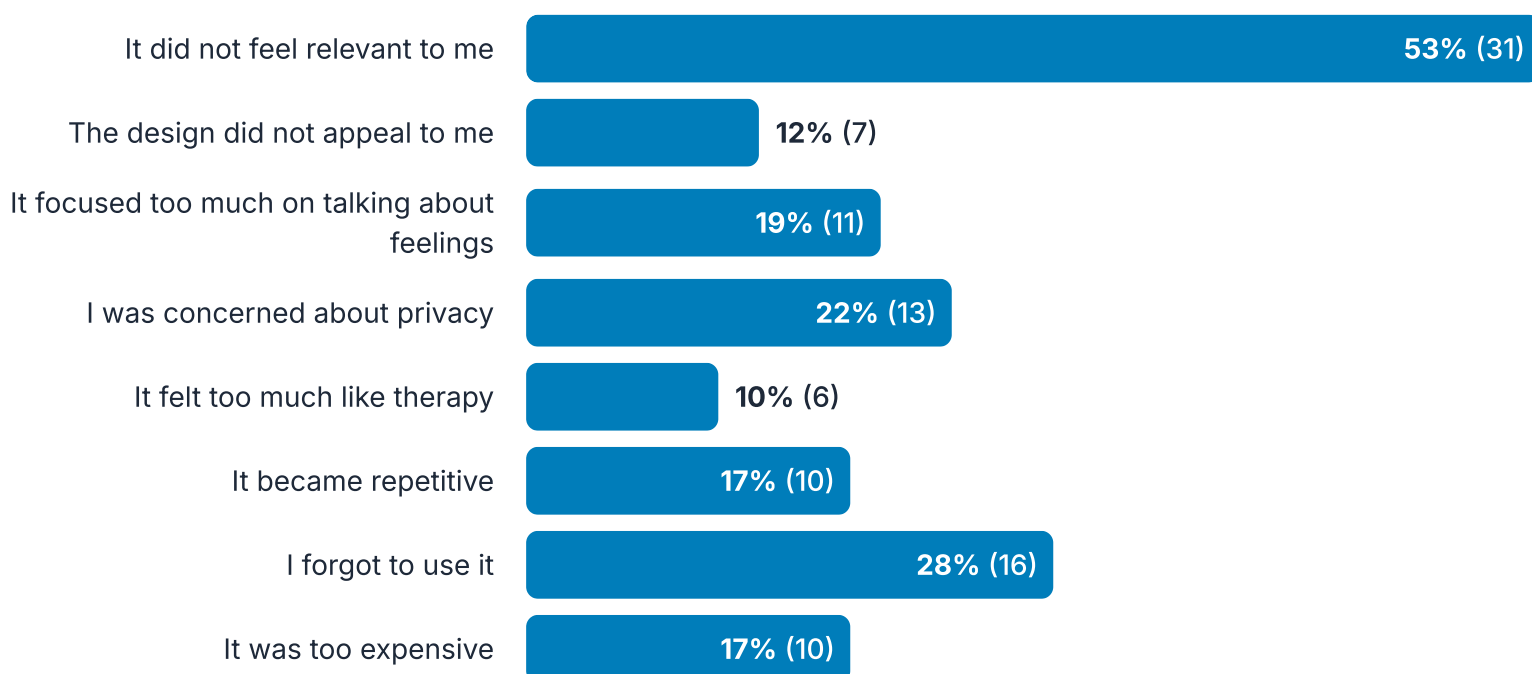
It's very generic and very elementary (suggested basic things I already know)

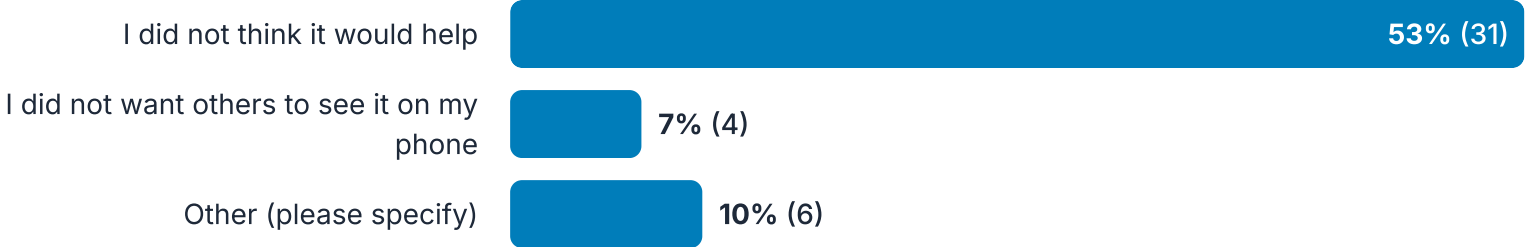
It has emergency meditation sessions for various emotions which helps a lot

Generic response of method

18. If you stopped using a wellbeing app or chose not to use one, why? (Select all that apply)

Responses: 58

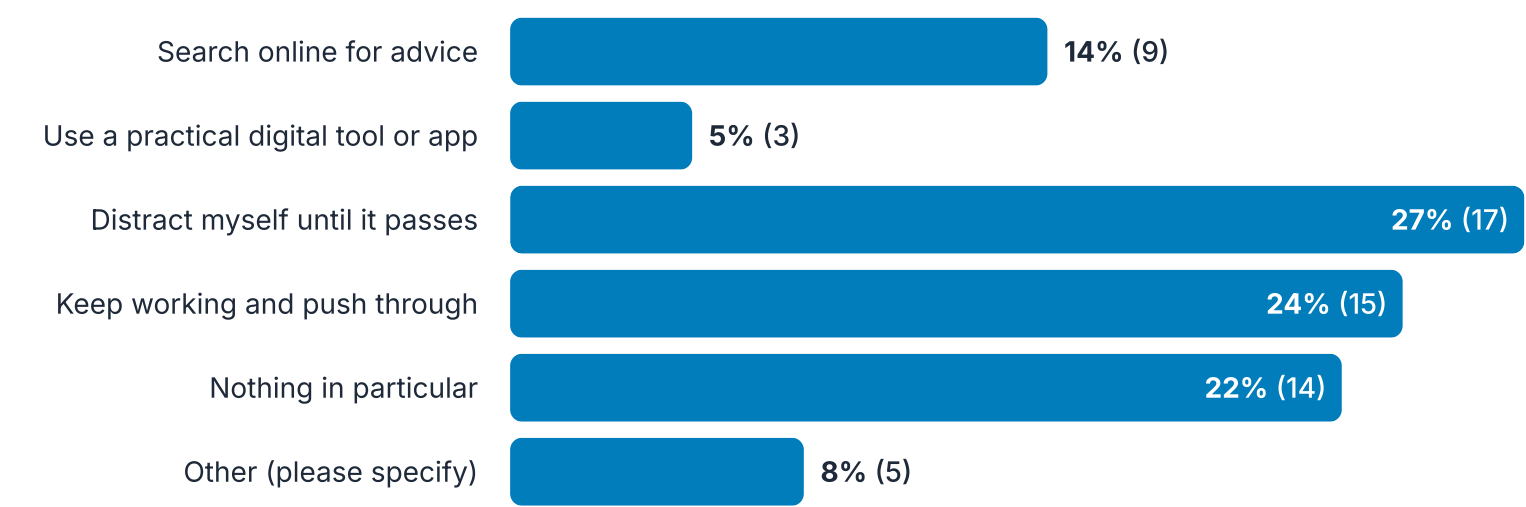




Other (please specify)

- Most of these apps are pro-psych. As a victim of the psych industry, i feel unsafe around psychologist rhetoric. Breathing exercises cause me panic attacks, because they remind me of the people who literally (yes, literally, psychologically, physically, and sexually) tortured me for the crime of being queer and autistic.
- lacks the human layer of connection, empathy and presence I need to feel seen
- I don't like generic wellbeing exercises that do not take my personal situation into account; i prefer irl support, i do not need to spend even more time on my phone
- I explained the main reason in the question 17
- requires too much time on something that I don't think will help. plus most of the advice is not new info. exercise, self care, talk to people. I can get the same benefit from googling advice
- I do not trust some random application to give worthwhile advice

19. If you could not easily talk to someone about a stressful situation, what would you most likely do instead? Responses: 63



Other (please specify)

- Sit with it alone

Meditation, journalling, walking, walking in nature, prioritising sleep, stretching, noticing if my thoughts are drifting back to it and avoiding lingering in negative ruminations. Eat, sleep, exercise, carry on. But realistically I would likely talk to someone about a stressful situation.

brainstorm w AI

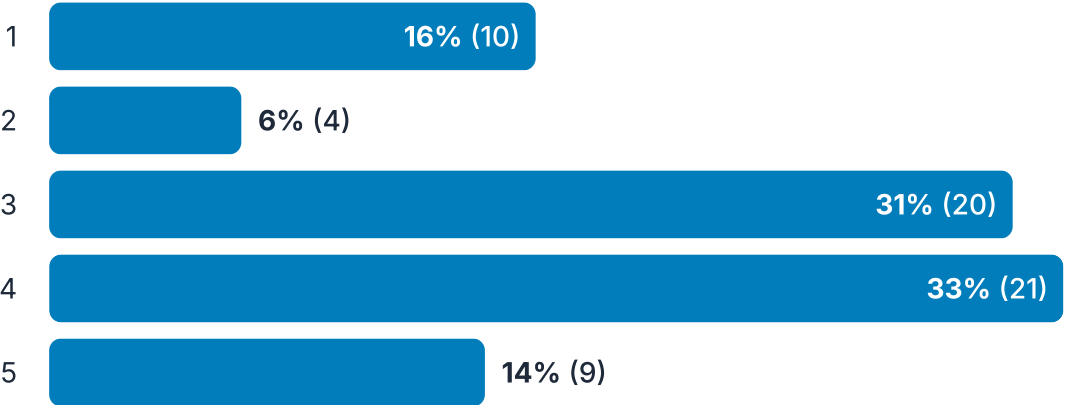
Identify the source of the stress and take action to fix it

Work out or masturbate (sorry for tmi) to force a change of hormones in my body; I've been through a lot and mentally, I'm quite tough, it's the physical manifestations of stress like high heart rate, tremors, lightheadedness, muscle tightness and cramps, insomnia etc. that I can't deal with

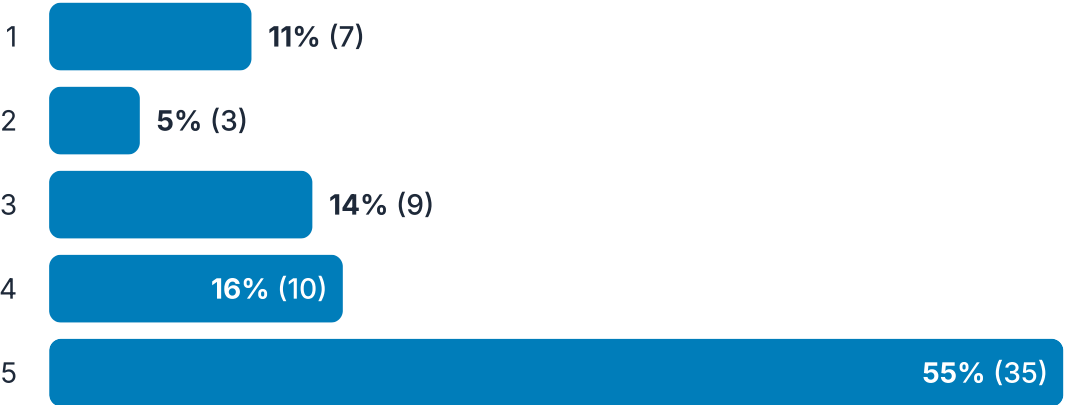
20. How important are the following features in a well-being app?Lowest rating: 1 and Highest rating: 5

Responses: 64

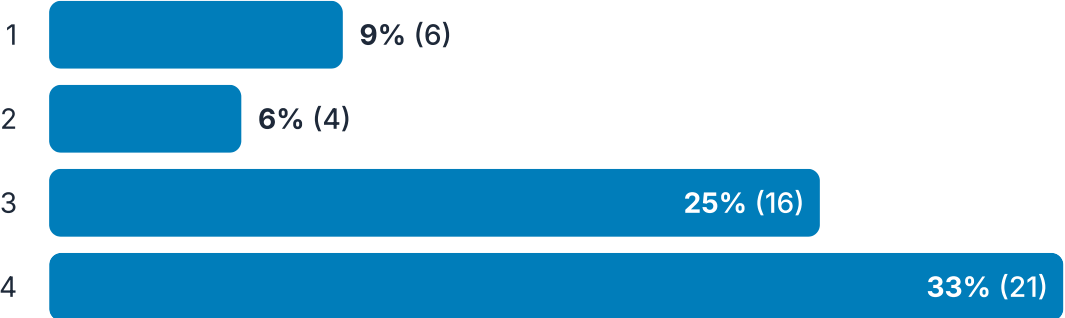
Quick activities (<2 min)

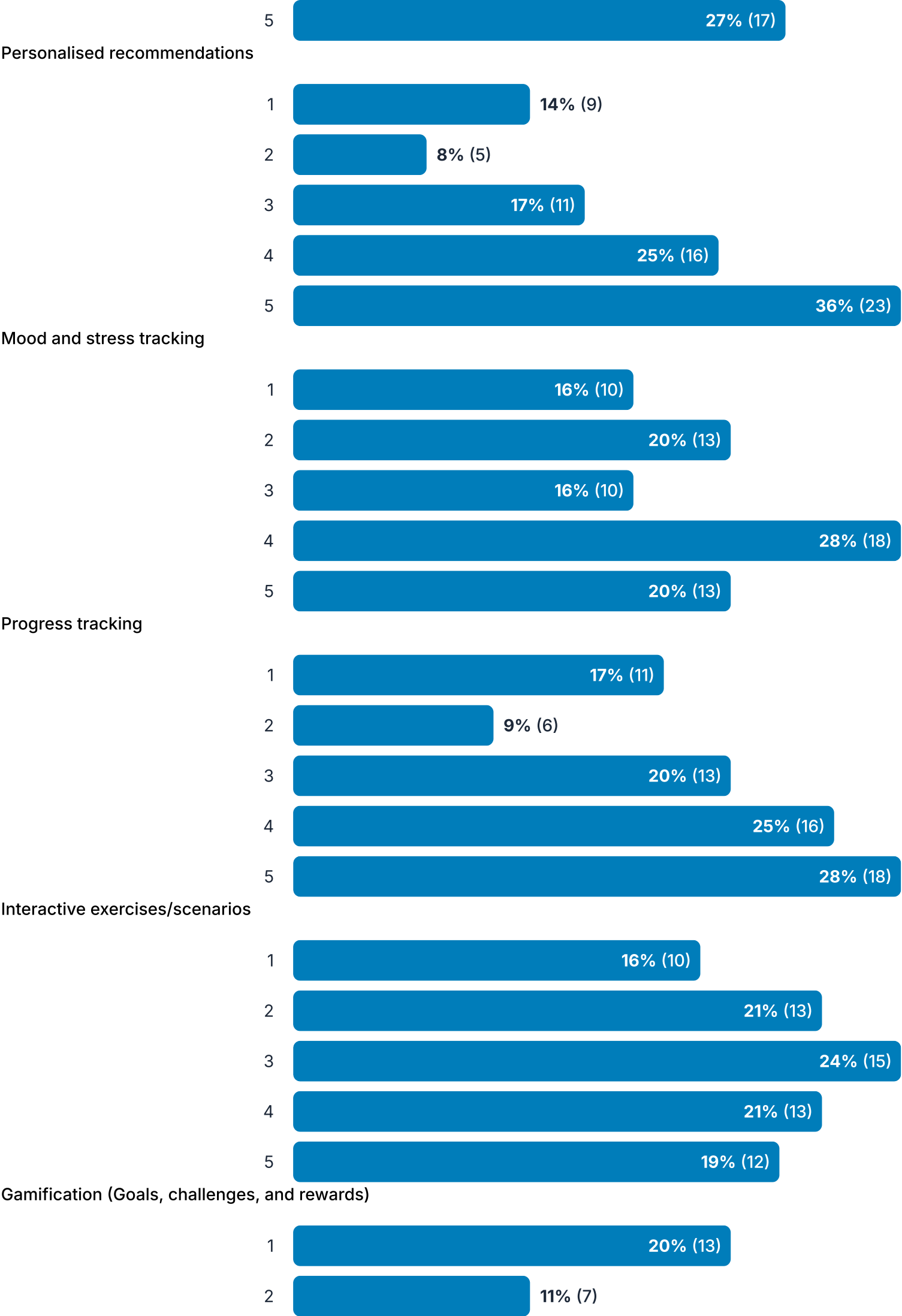


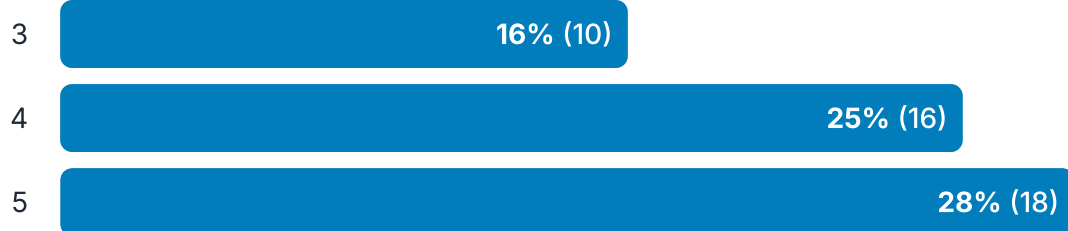
Anonymous use



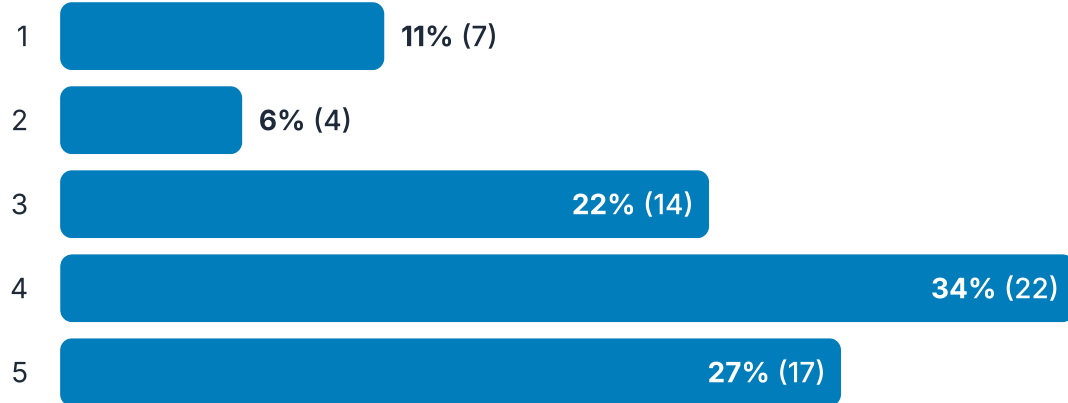
Practical stress-management advice/solutions



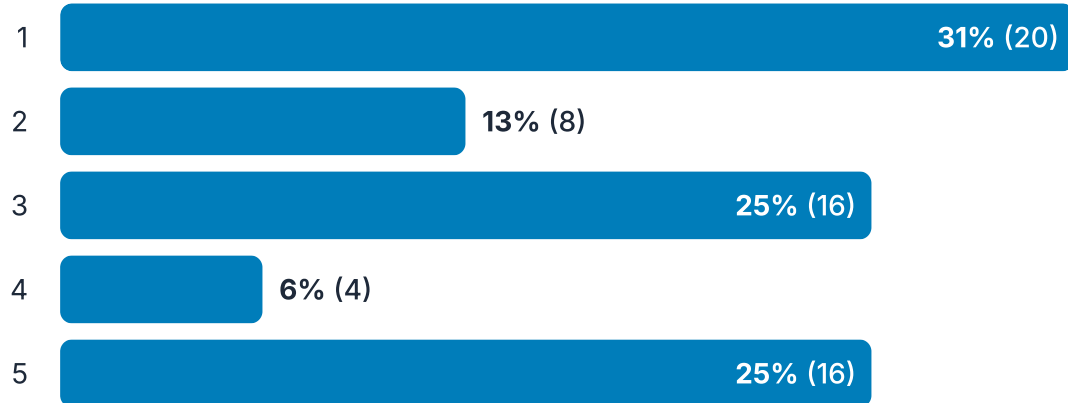




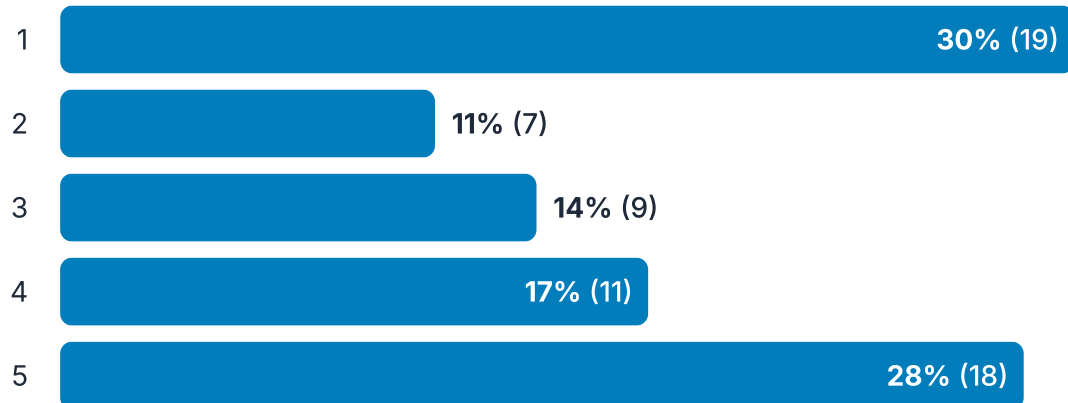
Activity-based wellbeing (walking, running, hobbies, etc.)



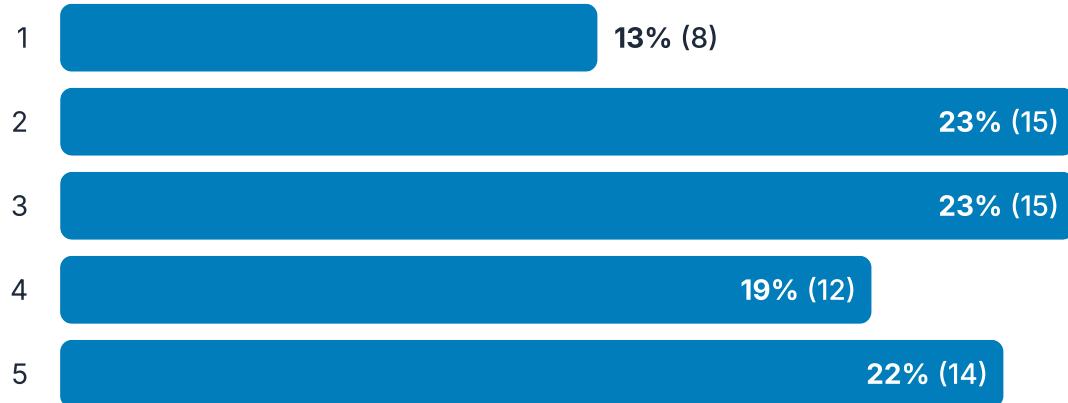
Community/social connection



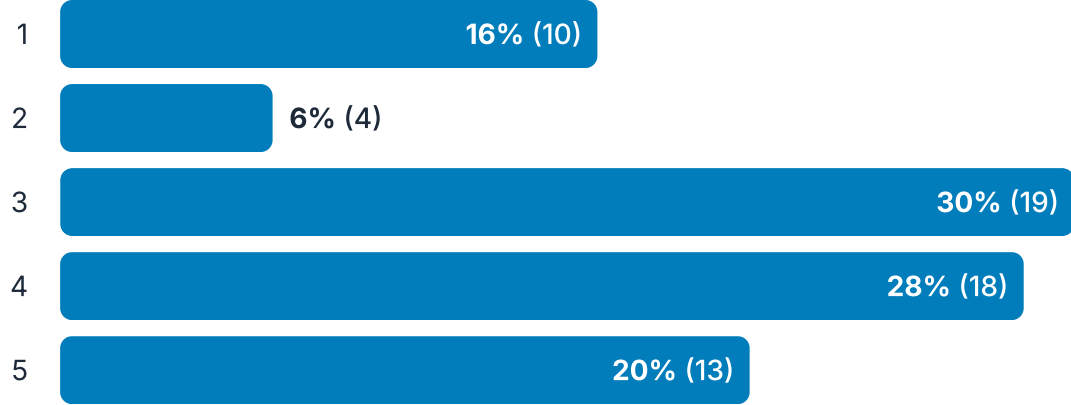
Health app integration (Apple Health, Strava, etc.)



Educational content about stress, emotions, and wellbeing



Simple, non-clinical design



21. Please indicate your agreement.

Responses: 64

I would avoid an app that obviously looks like a mental health app.



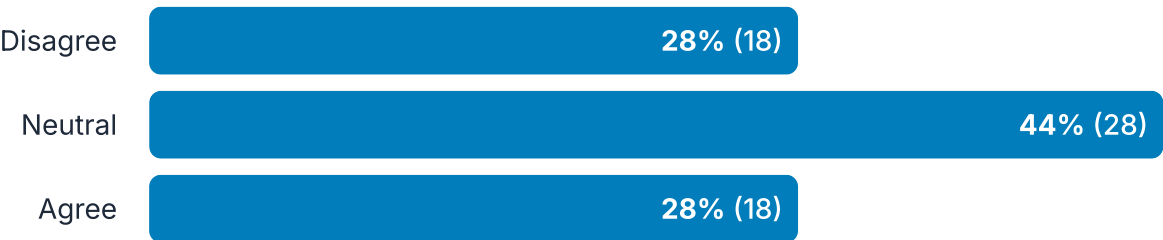
I prefer practical advice over emotional support



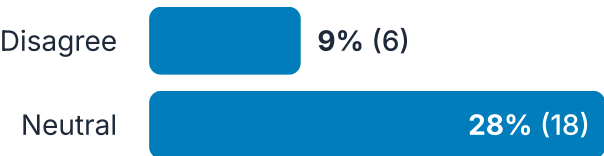
Privacy is very important to me



I would use an app more if it felt like a productivity or fitness app



I would trust an app that explains how my data is used



Section D – Your Thoughts

This is an optional section.

22. Thinking about a difficult period during the past year (for example, related to work, study, relationships, or finances), what helped you keep going? There is no right answer. This could be an activity, a routine, a habit, a tool, or just how you approached it. Please avoid including personal or identifying information.

Responses: 43

My friends/family bringing me down to earth

Knowing the deadline was fixed and I had to get my work done

speaking out about it to the uni wellbeing team, and staff member i felt comfortable with. speaking to my family about it, to not feel alone. speaking to a counselor/therapist in order to find a solution. trying to eat whole foods that will nourish my body and mind. try to stay active when possible. be kind to myself and not expect things that are unrealistic for me to achieve.

If it's work or life in general, I just keep going because the days keep moving anyway. If it's relationships, talking to the specific person usually helps. If it's finances, I started investing so I can still have some income even when I'm not working.

Honestly i keep going because i have to, when the emotions become numb, I just start doing it while being completely detached about the immediate outcome

Just been with friends and chilling. When I'm not doing anything, my mind wanders.

Keep on work kept myself super busy and let it get solved by itself

by getting busy with something else

Exercise and friends

The belief that there's light at the end of the tunnel

Distracting myself helped a lot in getting through

Managing my schedule and working on the issue

Hoping that things would be better and watching motivational videos

Pranyam and yoga and journaling

I started journaling. That is the most helpful thing that got me to lash out my frustration, anger and what i was going through. By journaling here i meant writing physically using pen and book and not in notion. Writing became my therapy. I am still struggling with a lot of things including some social anxiety and some career issues but i have accepted myself, what are my shortcomings and i am working on it everyday and trying to get better each day

I am extremely diligent, and I can keep myself going through pretty much anything. It can just suck and be harder to go through, but I am generally focused on the goal and know my work will pay off.

Honest answer? Escapist fiction writing (of worlds where i DON'T have to exist at all). If i didn't have a thousand stories in my head to get out before i go...

A close friend

the small chance it gets better

Still looking for that thing

Therapy. Several years of working on this stuff in different ways. Accountability. Routine. Structure. Education and good practice.

What else can I do other than keeping going

Prayer and motivating myself, motivational video too

Working on myself and learning from everything that I have tried and tested based on the situation that i was in.

Seeking help and not carrying the stress of everything alone. Learning to talk to the right people and gathering the right emotional tools that help me out in the long term.

Only the motivation to do better and constant support from family and friends by talking to them

There have been a lot of difficult times last year particularly finding the real purpose to my existence as well as finding a source of income. The only that keeps you going through are the small revelations that you go through and you could rephrase them as checkpoints. The most appalling yet blissful method is to snudge yourself out of your comfort zone while not knowing much of it.

My partner

Taking practical steps to change or adapt to the circumstances that were causing the stress.

For the longest time I just kept going and pushing myself until I came to some sort of a breaking point. Then I turned to AI for some help but it didn't really work. Then I turned to occupational health service which gave me good tricks and advice to try, and that finally helped me.

Knowledge that it would pass, as does everything.

Nothing in particular. I kept going because that's what you do. There isn't a choice you just get on with it. Talking about it or seeing someone about it seems like a genuine waste of time.

In-person counseling Hope Trust in my own capabilities

Deadlines that cannot be moved I have to push through

Realizing how much I have already overcome. I am used to thinking that I'm weak, but thinking about everything I have been through, if I was told the story of my life as if it was a story of someone else, I would, first of all, think that it was made up ("there's no way someone can get so much bullshit" or something like that), but I also would most certainly expect that person to give up, most probably commit suicide. And despite it all, here I am, alive and still haven't lost my marbles. So when I thought I can't do anything, realizing that I am much tougher than I think helped me pull through

Reading and playing games

Knowing when the stressful period would(/could) be over was comforting. Interaction with friends that had nothing to do with the stressful influences helped me get out of the mindset the most.

Just continuing with my daily routine (exercise, eating well, etc.), reading about other people's similar experiences online, and continuing through it knowing things would eventually get better.

NSSI and meditating and breathing exercises.

I found it helpful to focus on things one day at a time and remind myself that difficult times are temporary. Talking to people close to me and having their support also made things feel more manageable

Just always trying to find something in the future to be excited about.

Meditation, lifestyle discipline, and affirmation

If I'm stressing about work or other things I sometimes like to sit and play my games so my mind can wonder

23. Imagine an app designed specifically to help young men manage everyday pressure using practical, action-based activities rather than therapy or journaling. What features would make you want to use it regularly? Is there

Responses: 39

anything you would improve or change? Be as specific or as general as you like. Your answer will directly shape what gets built.

Something relevant to them-not sure

Being able to know where the advice was coming from and if it was advice from someone I admired it would be even better e.g. Chris Williamson or Naval Ravikant

unsure

I think I'll use it if I don't have to tell it "I'm under stress," but it can realize it by itself and tell me to do something that can pause the situation, even if it's just holding my breath for 10 seconds. Perhaps I can also quickly list down the things I'm dealing with, so I don't need to spend much time on it but can still trace them afterwards. If the app can help me analyze when and what usually puts me under stress, perhaps I'll become more aware of myself and my patterns. Also, I think having some kind of stress level or leveling system is important. I want to be able to see how stressed I am and whether it's getting better or worse over time.

I think getting the right help is a huge problem. Like if i think i need therapy, I won know where to turn to. I dont have the funds or time to waste money talking about my feelings to someone who wont actually help me. Knowing where to go and Being sure that this is the best place to go for your particular problem would be really helpful.

I have no thoughts on this, but perhaps a physical activity kinda games

Oh you know what Honestly speaking I would like a feature that provides me a specific person or I can be that person to catch up or just to chill around if the person is stressed

Making you part of a group activity

1-2 minute voice recording of my thoughts through the day

While practical advice would be useful, emotional support would be something I would rather look for.

Daily activity tracker

Exercise tracking and how I am utilising my time Specially track my screen time and what app is being used in what way

When i open the app it should feel like a soothing experience and ask me thr right question to know my situation and give me and activity to do that will help me a prompt for journaling or walking bare foot or anything

Walking, working out, eating healthy (sometimes anxiety or pressure is vitamins and nutrients deficiency) and being able to talk to someone who actually understands us. Men are lonely beings. No one will admit but they are. Even the ones who have big friends circle and are always with someone are lonely. They will only realize it when they have nothing to give. Only true people who gets men are their sisters or their mothers, else everyone else is trying to get something out of him or are trying to use him. And if a men can get a partner like that, i'd advise to never leave her. Being able to identify if its an actual pressure or it's just a peer pressure. Sometimes,

we just think its a stress but its often not Doing a physical activity everyday atleast for 1 hour, could be running, playing pickle ball or a basketball

Gamification, showing me my data or progress over time. Some community aspect to where I could interact anonymously with others. Some easy way to make it a habit, that's the hard part.

It would need to be totally devoid of psych rhetoric. Inclusive. Let me use my lowercase "i" pronouns. Don't assume that i'm human. Just don't make all the assumptions that psychs do then pathologize and patronize people over when their assumptions are wrong. Allow total anonymity and privacy.

Gentle, encouraging reminders. And being very forgiving.

i dont think there is one, sorry

Why only keep them limited to that? If the app were pitched as practical action-based approaches, I would still keep trying to lead them toward therapy, journalling, and meditation AS WELL. Make it part of the gamification. Find ways to normalise that. Pennebaker (1996) would argue that one doesn't even need to get a person as far as therapy to reap the health benefits of disclosure - normalising disclosure with people who are initially uncomfortable with it is a much smarter play than avoiding it. I could also argue that if someone is that resistant to therapy/disclosure then they would likely be resistant to the app in general - one should never try to deceive somebody into working on their mental health, so any app that addresses it should just be up front and try to keep the person on board if they're already interested. Those who are, keep leading them toward activity + ways of talking, but I think avoiding the latter rather than normalising it would be a terrible approach for your app. I run a men's talking/sharing group, and will argue with anyone that "guys don't like talking about their feelings"... they do, you just have to figure out how to signal to them that "this is the time, this is the place, let's do this..." . For the resistant guys it's usually less that they don't want to talk about their feelings, and more that they don't want to be perceived as "weak" if they do. Finding ways for this to be a quiet thing they can do on their own, or that the space is safe from any of that kind of judgement : this is the way. Everybody likes talking about their feelings - just gotta figure out how to get them to pick up the microphone :)

Organised activities that are cheap and help build community, educational content that allows people to understand the root cause of their stress, understanding what's external vs internal and information on different pathways for types of therapy

Voice function

Daily goals. Personalised recommendations. Self diagnostic and information about it.

Therapy *is* a tool that enables men and everyone else with practical, action-based tools, not sure why we would want to feed the general aversion towards it than trying to build a positive notion around more men trying it out. If i really had to think on features, i'd want something that encourages young men to actually articulate their feelings and get in touch with their emotional mind. i think it's important, especially in today's world, to encourage men to be more vocal about how they feel, to help them move forward with clarity in thought and make informed decisions rather than using quickfixes that work like a band aid. well rounded adults are formed when they learn to sit with themselves and the discomfort life puts them through, a feature that helps them stay grounded and promotes that mentality overall would be a good place to start

maybe some achievement related things which showcase some sort of milestone that I have come to.

It should be able to push me out of my comfort zone via creativity, curiosity and hard work. It simpler to work hard once you have enough information or idea about something that you want to do. But at the same time the feeling of pushing yourself through your PRs each day (or even attempting them) makes your day feel worth it (gym related analogy). It is difficult for an app to focus on all sorts of diverse things. But the source of mostly everything is just curiosity.

I have a hard time picturing anything I think a young man would want to use. Maybe... MAYBE something with short stories and good quotes.

I would want it to be a website accessible via a Windows laptop. Not a phone app.

Gamification might work, and I think concrete things you could checkmark as done in a minute or two would be the key to keep on coming back to it

I'm not a young man and honestly don't understand the way this chronically online generation think or respond.

I'm not sure what that would look like. When I am stressed I just tend to focus on necessary things because I don't have the energy or interest required to do extra activities. Fortunately I get plenty of exercise just doing daily routine things so I'm not sure extra action based things would help much.

Would not use such an app Also I'm not a "young man" anymore

Easy exercises that can be performed at home

I'm a man, but I think activity-based approach is just as bad as journaling. What would help me personally would be minimal journaling or activities, replaced by a very quick and straightforward numerical progress bar or something (and I said, "numbers going up") - like tracking the days since unhealthy coping mechanism was used the last time with one press confirmation button, a counter how many stressful events you already overcame, etc. Probably a quick list of solutions I fill/prioritize once when installing that I can pull up if I'm overwhelmed and can't think straight. A long streak makes people more reluctant to break it.

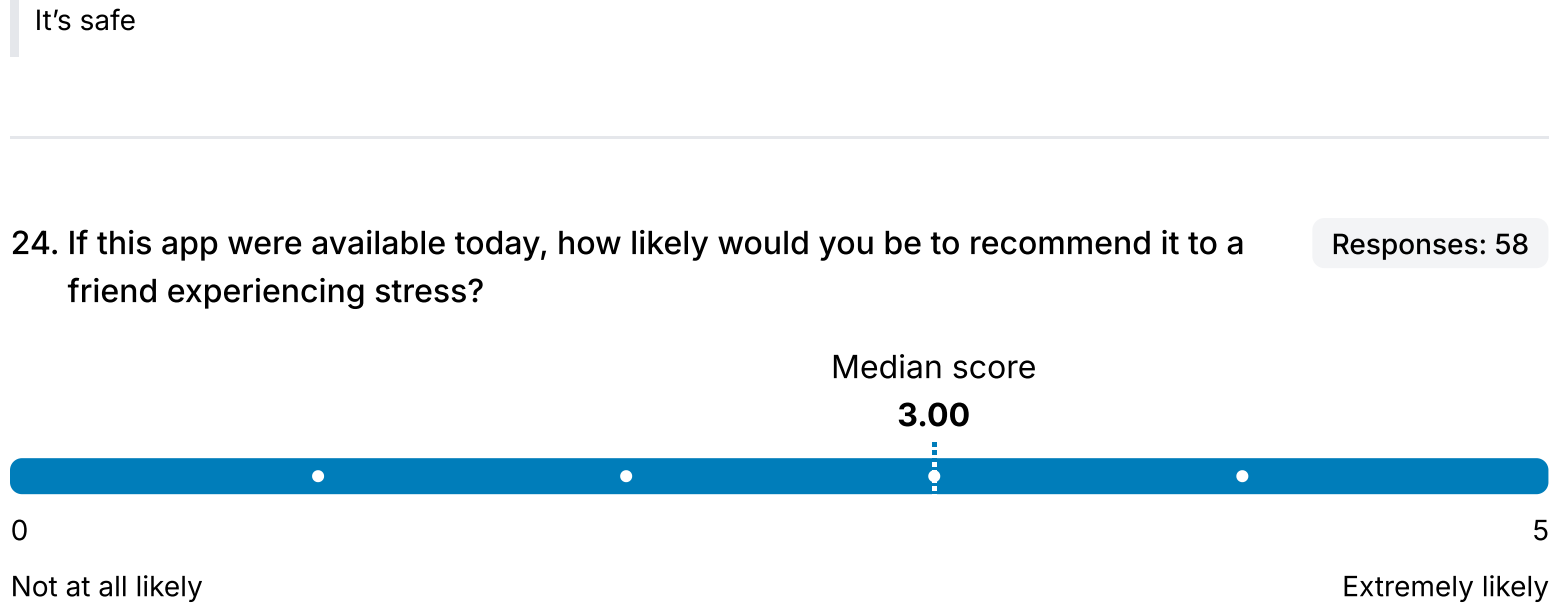
Progress tracking, communicating practical advice routinely with notifications set by users

Very low barriers, so it's easy to pick up every day. Actual useful content that keeps it interesting to come back, and probably some gamification (although I'd argue that's not always very conducive to better mental health)

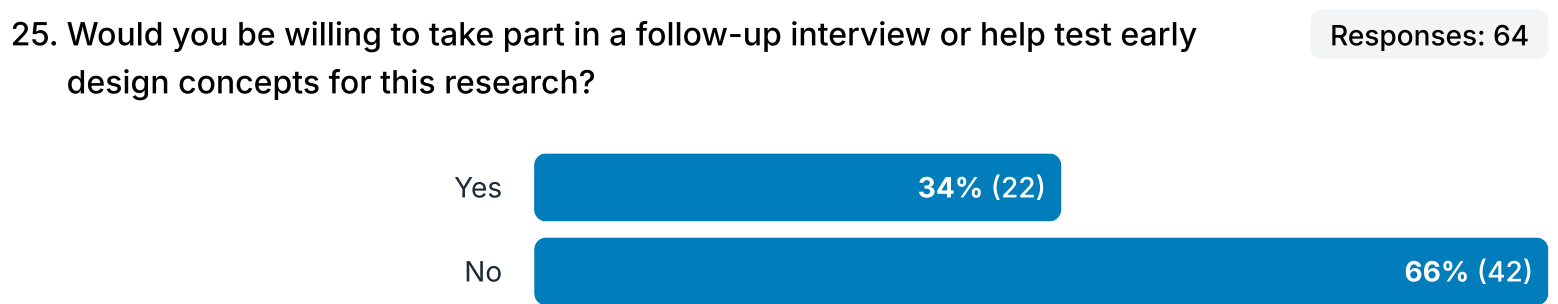
I'm not a man so unsure if this is relevant, but a focus on what activities work FOR ME rather than generic or fake "personalized" recommended content (possibly the only thing worse than generic content) would be best. Maybe starting with a survey to identify what actions have given the person relief in the past and then building a step by step plan based on those actions?

I'd want it to be simple and practical, with short activities. Daily goals and progress tracking could also encourage regular use. I'd avoid too much reading or journaling and make the activities quick and easy to fit into everyday life

Interaction with professional



Section E – Future Participation (Optional)



26. Please provide your email address if you would like to be contacted about future stages of this research. Your email address will be stored separately from your survey responses to maintain your anonymity.

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